The CLEAR Change Framework: A powerful path to transformation

By Erik Bohjort, Licensed Psychologist – Creator of the CLEAR Framework

Executive Summary

In today's era of relentless disruption, organizations must change or risk irrelevance. Yet change is hard – *over 70% of transformation initiatives fail* (innovationone), often because people lack clarity of purpose and genuine engagement. The **CLEAR Change Framework** is a five-step model designed to flip the script on failed change. **CLEAR** stands for **Clarity, Leverage, Experimentation, Analysis, Refinement** – a sequence that balances a *clear North Star vision* with *agile, iterative execution*. This whitepaper introduces CLEAR as a practical and inspirational approach to drive transformation. We compare CLEAR with established models (like Kotter's 8 Steps, ADKAR, and Lean Change) to validate its principles, and we'll highlight real-world success stories – from **Starbucks**' dramatic turnaround to **Earth Force**' grassroots innovation and the **UK Policy Lab**'s pioneering experiments.

CLEAR doesn't ask you to abandon what works in traditional change management; instead, it **integrates proven ideas** (e.g. the importance of vision and reinforcement) with a modern, *adaptive learning* mindset. The result is a framework that feels *reassuringly familiar* while adding something new and holistic. By the end of this paper, you'll see how CLEAR can help your organization not only *manage* change, but **harness it** as a source of competitive advantage and renewal. It's an invitation to a journey of transformation – one grounded in evidence, infused with inspiration, and oriented towards real business results.

Introduction

Change as Opportunity, Not Obligation

Change is often approached with dread – employees fear the unknown, leaders fear failure. But what if change could be reframed as an opportunity to **evolve and innovate** continuously? The CLEAR Framework was born from the recognition that in a world of rapid shifts (technological advances, market disruptions, societal changes), successful organizations are those that *learn and adapt faster* than the competition. They balance *strategic clarity* with *agility*, much like a surfer who needs a steady stance (clarity of direction) and the ability to adjust on the fly (experimentation and refinement) to ride the waves.

Traditional change models have given us valuable foundations. Kotter's classic 8-Step model, for example, underscores the need for urgency, strong leadership, and a clear vision; Prosci's ADKAR model highlights the human side of change, ensuring individuals move through awareness and desire to new behaviors (prosci) (whatfix). These frameworks have high success rates in structured environments, but they can struggle in today's volatile context. Kotter's method is *deliberately linear* and heavily top-down – great for marching through a known game plan, but rigid when you face unexpected detours (prosci). ADKAR ensures no person is left behind emotionally, yet by itself it doesn't tell you *how to redesign processes or experiment with new ideas*. And newer approaches like **Lean Change Management** emphasize iterative "change experiments" for continuous improvement (pmi), aligning well with agile values, but may not explicitly start with a unifying vision.

CLEAR was developed to bridge these gaps. It provides a **structured yet flexible** roadmap for change. The five steps ensure you start with purpose and end with sustainable improvement, while cycling through testing and learning in between. Importantly, CLEAR also encourages a *systems-thinking* view: changes are understood in context, and feedback loops drive adaptation at the organizational and environmental level (not just in isolated pockets). The framework is grounded in behavioral science and organizational psychology – acknowledging that clarity reduces fear (whatfix), that people support what they help create (innovationone), and that iterative trial-and-error beats grand plans in uncertainty (prosci).

In the following sections, we'll break down each of the five CLEAR steps, supported by evidence and examples. You'll see how CLEAR incorporates the best of earlier models while adding its own strengths. Whether you're an executive leading an enterprise-wide transformation or a team leader driving a change initiative, CLEAR offers a compelling guide to make change less of a daunting mandate and more of an *inspired journey* of discovery and progress.

The Five Steps of CLEAR: A Framework Overview

CLEAR is an acronym encapsulating the five core stages of this change approach:

- **Clarity** – Define a clear vision and purpose for the change. (What are we doing and *why*?)
- **Leverage** – Harness existing strengths, resources, leverage points and localize people to support the change. (What can we build on? Who can champion this?)
- **Experimentation** – Take action through small-scale experiments or pilots. (How can we *try out* ideas safely and learn fast?)
- **Analysis** – Evaluate the outcomes of experiments with data and insight. (What happened, and *why*? What does the feedback tell us?)
- **Refinement** – Integrate the lessons learned to refine the approach, then expand or adjust as needed. (How do we make it better? How do we embed successful changes and iterate again?)

These steps form a continuous cycle. After Refinement, you often loop back to all of the previous steps, re-clarify or leverage new learnings as you push the change further. In essence, CLEAR combines a **big-picture compass** (Clarity) with a **continuous improvement cycles** (Experiment–Analysis–Refinement repeating, supported by Leverage at every turn). It's akin to the Deming **Plan-Do-Check-Act (PDCA) cycle**, a proven iterative method where *"the cycle should be repeated again and again for continuous improvement"* (asq) (theleanway). Just as PDCA is an ongoing loop, CLEAR encourages constant adaptation until the change goals are redefined or achieved and ingrained.

In the next sections, we delve into each step, illustrating how to execute them and why they work. We'll draw parallels to other frameworks to reinforce their integrity and show how together they create a dynamic yet disciplined path for change.

Step 1: Clarity – Defining Vision and Purpose

All change must begin with a **clear and compelling purpose**. Clarity means everyone understands *what* we are changing and *why* it matters. This step establishes the guiding star for all that follows. Without clarity; confusion and skepticism will fill the void – an all-too-common reason that employees resist change ("I know something's changing, but I have no idea why this is happening to us") (whatfix).

Clarity in CLEAR involves crafting a vision or goal that is simple, concrete, and meaningful. It's not just a slogan from the C-suite; it should resonate at all levels. Leaders spearheading the change must communicate this vision *early and often*, tying it to core values and urgent business needs. John Kotter identified "creating a strategic vision and initiative" as a critical early step in successful transformations (prosci).

Likewise, the ADKAR model's first milestone is **Awareness** – making individuals aware of why the change is necessary (whatfix). In practice, this means sharing honest facts about the challenges or opportunities prompting the change, and painting a vivid picture of a better future once the change is achieved.

One powerful example of clarity comes from **Starbucks' transformation** in the late 2000s. Returning as CEO during a crisis, Howard Schultz set out a *"clear, unwavering message"* that the company's transformation would be a **return to its roots and values** (libraryhbsedu). He explicitly recommitted Starbucks to its core principles – the love of coffee and the human connection in the cafe experience – as the non-negotiable guide for all changes. This clarity of purpose ("evoke the heritage and passion for the true Starbucks Experience" (libraryhbsedu) rallied employees around why changes like closing underperforming stores or altering operations were needed. Clarity became a source of inspiration: rather than lamenting cutbacks, partners (employees) understood these moves were to *save the soul of the company* and protect what made them proud to work there.

Such clarity also provides a **moral compass** during tough decisions. It answers the employees' burning question: "What's in it for me (or our customers) if we go through this upheaval?" When articulated well, a clear purpose taps into emotions – pride, shared values, the desire to be part of something meaningful – *engaging hearts*, not just minds. It creates alignment: departments and teams can then set their own sub-goals consistent with the overarching vision. As one Forbes analysis noted, during Starbucks' turnaround the leadership sent a *consistent message* about returning to core values, which helped ensure every initiative, from product changes to store training, served a common aim (libraryhbsedu).

Establishing clarity isn't a one-off task. It must be maintained throughout the change journey. Communicate progress in terms of the vision ("We're 50% towards our goal of X, which means we're delivering on the promise we made to customers"). Reiterate the

why at milestones, especially if course corrections are needed. Clarity anchors the organization when the seas get rough – it is the ever-present reference point that keeps everyone oriented toward the desired destination.

Step 2: Leverage – Harnessing Strengths Through Systems Thinking

With a clear vision in hand, the next step is to strategically leverage everything you've got to support the change. No organization starts from scratch—you already have assets, resources, expertise, and passionate individuals that can be powerful catalysts for transformation. Leverage, within CLEAR, means working smarter by strategically mobilizing your existing strengths, identifying critical leverage points, and systematically addressing barriers through a systems-thinking approach. This is best articulated through three interconnected elements—**People, Points of Change, and Problems**:

1. People – Mobilizing Champions and Catalysts

People are the lifeblood of any successful change initiative. Change management research consistently demonstrates that engaging a critical mass of stakeholders vastly improves success rates. A McKinsey study of 60 organizations found that transformations engaging at least 7% of employees actively in the change effort were twice as likely to succeed. Companies involving 20–30% of employees saw nearly four times the impact (innovationone). The lesson here is clear: people support what they help create.

In practice, this means identifying and mobilizing those who embody your organization's strengths, values, and expertise. This includes formal leaders, influential employees, frontline team members, and informal change champions. Starbucks provides a vivid example of this principle in action: during their 2008 turnaround, CEO Howard Schultz boldly engaged his "partners" (employees), closing all U.S. stores for a day of retraining 135,000 baristas and later convening a global leadership conference of store managers—even amid financial strain. Schultz understood that leveraging their people's passion and culture was pivotal to successfully implementing changes at scale (libraryhbsedu).

By strategically empowering people early and broadly, your initiative will gain momentum, credibility, and resilience.

2. Points of Change – Identifying Nodes for Maximum Impact

Organizations operate as complex networks of interconnected teams, processes, and departments. Each of these units functions as a node within your organizational system. By clearly mapping and understanding these nodes, you identify leverage points where targeted interventions can deliver disproportionate benefits. Focusing your efforts on these critical nodes ensures that even small adjustments produce significant ripple effects across the entire system.

Consider again Starbucks: they didn't randomly choose to improve everything simultaneously. Instead, they identified a few critical operational nodes—like in-store processes and barista workflows—that, if enhanced, would drastically elevate the customer experience across thousands of stores (bigthink). Similarly, Earth Force, an NGO promoting youth civic engagement, carefully selected partnerships with schools and community organizations as key nodes, amplifying their impact without substantially expanding their own resources (earthforce).

Identifying and strategically targeting these leverage points allows you to generate substantial results efficiently, turning limited resources into transformative outcomes.

3. Problems – Systematically Addressing Barriers

Every system and each node within it faces inherent obstacles—structural, cultural, procedural—that can slow or block progress. Effective leveraging requires explicitly identifying and addressing these barriers. Analyze what moderates or inhibits change within your system, develop clear strategies to mitigate these issues, and thus foster an environment in which change can flourish.

Returning to the Starbucks example, their leadership recognized specific barriers, such as inconsistent employee training practices and inefficient store layouts, that limited their partners' effectiveness. They systematically tackled these problems through retraining initiatives and lean process improvements, enabling partners to focus more on customer interactions rather than unnecessary tasks (6sigma).

In practice, addressing problems requires deep listening and insight from frontline stakeholders, who often best understand the practical barriers. Removing these barriers creates an environment in which positive change can thrive and become sustainable.

Leveraging Leverage

This combined approach—mobilizing **People**, strategically selecting **Points of Change**, and systematically addressing **Problems**—brings clarity and depth to the Leverage phase of CLEAR. It ensures you're not just leveraging what's obvious, but using a structured, systems-based approach to multiply your effectiveness.

Leverage, then, is both an analytical and deeply human-centric step: it integrates storytelling (engaging stakeholders through meaningful narratives), systems-thinking (mapping and prioritizing points of change), and tactical problem-solving (removing barriers and enhancing flows within the system). When executed thoughtfully, Leverage creates conditions in which Experimentation, Analysis, and Refinement can unfold more smoothly, naturally, and sustainably—transforming your change initiative into a powerful engine of ongoing improvement.

Step 3: Experimentation – Driving Change Through Action and Learning

With clarity of vision and a coalition of support in place, it's time to **take action**. Rather than betting everything on a big-bang rollout, CLEAR advocates for **Experimentation** – testing ideas on a small scale, learning from them, and iterating. This step injects agility and creativity into the change process. It replaces paralysis (or endless planning) with a bias for action, while controlling risk by keeping experiments manageable in scope.

Modern change approaches increasingly highlight experimentation as best practice. **Lean Change Management**, for instance, treats change initiatives as a series of hypotheses to be tested – Jason Little, a pioneer of Lean Change, talks about running *"minimal viable changes"* as experiments through stages of prepare, introduce, and learn (pmi). In the **public sector**, innovation units like the UK's **Policy Lab** use prototyping extensively to improve policies. In fact, the UK Policy Lab has embedded a *"prototyping mindset"* in government, where policy ideas are trialed through prototypes before full implementation (openpolicy). In one project, the Policy Lab brought together 35 stakeholders to co-create over 50 ideas, then **developed 8 prototypes** (from simple storyboards to mock digital tools) which they tested with real users (openpolicy). This process allowed them to see what worked and what didn't in a matter of months, refining marine policy plans in a way that traditional top-down drafting could never match (openpolicy).

Experimentation in CLEAR means identifying the key assumptions or questions within your change initiative and finding ways to get quick feedback on them. For example, if the change is a new customer service process, an experiment could be piloting it in one branch or with one product line to observe results. If it's an organizational restructuring, perhaps experiment with one department's workflow adjustments before company-wide reorganization. The idea is to create **safe-to-fail experiments**: controlled trials that won't catastrophically hurt the business if they go wrong, but from which you can gather valuable data. This is very much in line with the agile principle of incremental development and the scientific method of hypothesize -> test -> evaluate.

It's worth noting that a culture that embraces experimentation is typically more innovative and adaptable. When employees see leadership endorsing small experiments, it sends a powerful message: *it's okay to not have all the answers up front*. We are figuring this out together, and your observations from these trials are important. This mindset can be contagious. In times of change, it replaces fear of the unknown with curiosity – "Let's try this and see what we learn" becomes the prevailing attitude.

Real-world example: During its lean transformation, Starbucks deployed an interesting experiment to tackle inefficiencies. They had noticed baristas were wasting motion in stores – moving around too much, which slowed service. Starbucks' lean team (led by a "VP of Lean Thinking") went store to store with a stopwatch **and even a Mr. Potato Head toy** to gamify process improvement (bigthink). They challenged store managers to

assemble the toy faster as an analogy for reducing motion in drink-making. This experiment in the field yielded eye-opening insights: they quantified that *30% of barista time was spent in unnecessary motion* (bigthink). That data point galvanized support for changes like re-arranging tools and ingredients at the workstation. In one Chicago store, simple adjustments (moving syrup bottles and whipped cream closer to where drinks are finished) shaved 8 seconds off a 45-second drink prep time, and customer satisfaction scores jumped 20 percentage points in just a few months (6sigma). Notice the pattern: **small experiment -> measure -> learn -> implement change**. This embodies CLEAR's Experimentation and leads naturally into the next step, Analysis.

When planning experiments, define what metrics or observations you will collect. Be sure to include front-line employees in designing experiments – they often have creative ideas and will be more bought in if they helped craft the trial. Also, set boundaries: duration, scope, and a clear hypothesis ("We believe doing X will result in Y outcome"). That way, everyone knows it's a test, not a permanent new policy (at least not yet). This reduces anxiety about change – people often fear that a new idea will be imposed irrevocably; knowing it's just an experiment makes them more willing to try it and to provide honest feedback.

In summary, **Experimentation** turns grand plans into tangible actions. It accelerates learning and keeps the change initiative from stagnating in endless analysis or planning. It's the engine that propels CLEAR forward, and it embodies the ethos of *adaptive change*: act, learn, and adjust rather than "freeze, plan, and pray." However, to truly benefit from experiments, we need to consciously learn from them – that's where **Analysis** comes in.

Step 4: Analysis – Learning and Measuring What Works

Every experiment generates information – some expected, some surprising. The **Analysis** step is about capturing that information and turning it into actionable insights. In CLEAR, Analysis ensures that change is evidence-driven: we double down on things that work, and we course-correct or discard things that don't, based on real data and feedback.

Analysis in this context has two facets: **quantitative metrics** (the hard data) and **qualitative insights** (observations, stories, sentiments from people involved). A robust analysis looks at both. For example, if you ran a pilot of a new sales strategy in two regions, the quantitative data might be sales numbers, customer retention rates, or service response times. The qualitative side might include sales reps' feedback, customer comments, or morale levels in those regions. Combining these helps avoid misinterpretation. Numbers can tell you *what* happened; people can often tell you the story of *why*.

The importance of analysis and reflection in change is well established. It's the "Check" in Plan-Do-Check-Act – Deming's cycle emphasizes that after trying something (Do), one must study the results (Check) to inform next actions (theleanwa). In the world of agile software, teams hold *retrospectives* at the end of each sprint to analyze what went well or poorly, fostering continuous team learning. Similarly, Lean Change Management explicitly includes a **"Learn"** state for each change experiment (pmi)– gathering insights is a built-in part of the flow.

How to conduct Analysis in CLEAR? As your experiments conclude or reach checkpoints, gather the relevant stakeholders to review results. Use clear criteria tied back to your Clarity step: how are we tracking against our vision and success metrics? Perhaps you set a goal to improve customer satisfaction by 10 points – did the experiment move the needle? In Starbucks' lean store trial, analysis of one store's data showed a *20% increase in transactions* after changes, confirming the approach's effectiveness (6sigma). Also, analyze *why*: in that case, it was the reduction of non-value-added work (less walking, bending) that freed partners to focus on customers (bigthink) (6sigma).

It's useful to document the findings of each experiment in a simple, visible way – for instance, a one-page summary or even a dashboard if quantitative. Some organizations use a **"change canvas"** or experiment log to track hypotheses, results, and next steps (a practice borrowed from Lean Startup and adapted for change initiatives). By keeping a record, you build an organizational memory of what was learned.

During analysis, be objective and curious. Not all experiments will succeed; in fact, a "failed" experiment (one that didn't yield the desired outcome) can be extremely valuable if it prevents the company from rolling out a flawed solution broadly. Treat failures as learning, not blame games. Ask: What did we learn about our customers/employees/system from this? Did anything unexpected happen? Sometimes analysis might reveal that an idea works *but in a different way than anticipated* – maybe your new process didn't speed up cycle time, but it improved quality, suggesting a different benefit to consider.

In addition to looking backward at the experiment, analysis should zoom out and consider external data or benchmarks. For example, if you're implementing a new marketing approach, how do the pilot results compare to industry benchmarks? Are there external factors (seasonality, economic changes) that might have influenced the outcome?

A key output of **Analysis** is a set of **recommendations or decisions**. Based on what we learned, what should we do next? This flows directly into the **Refinement** step. Perhaps the analysis shows the change delivered positive results in one setting but needs tweaks in another – that insight will shape how you refine and expand the change.

In sum, Analysis is the conscience of the CLEAR cycle – it keeps the process honest and reality-based. It transforms raw data into wisdom, ensuring the change effort is not guided by assumption or wishful thinking, but by *knowledge*. It appeals to the logical side (logos) of the initiative, which in turn boosts credibility (ethos) with stakeholders: people trust a change process that clearly shows "we tried this, here's what we found, and here's what we're doing because of it" (pmi). That transparency builds confidence and buy-in, fueling the momentum into the final step, Refinement.

Step 5: Refinement – Adapting and Embedding the Change

After analyzing results, it's time to **Refine** the approach – to adjust, improve, and then implement at larger scale with the benefit of what's been learned. Refinement is where change initiatives evolve from trial phase to sustained reality. It involves both **tweaking the solution** and **strengthening the implementation** (training, support, integration with existing processes) so the change can stick.

Think of Refinement as the "Act" in Plan-Do-Check-Act: you act on the lessons learned by updating your plan, and then you proceed – which often means looping back to *deploy more experiments or roll out the refined change more broadly*. This iterative cycling can continue until the change objective is fully met. The mantra here is **continuous improvement** – even after a change is implemented, you keep refining it as new information emerges. *"Just as a circle has no end, the PDCA cycle should be repeated again and again for continuous improvement,"* as the American Society for Quality succinctly puts it (asq).

In the **CLEAR framework**, Refinement might include:

- **Scaling up** what worked. If a pilot was successful, plan how to extend it to more teams, locations, or customer groups. Use the champions and knowledge from the pilot to guide the rollout.
- **Adjusting or redesigning** elements that didn't work perfectly. Perhaps an experiment showed a new software tool improved efficiency but employees felt confused by one feature; refinement could involve improving the tool's UX or providing better training before a wider launch.
- **Institutionalizing** the change. This means updating standard operating procedures, job descriptions, KPIs, or policies to reflect the new way. It's about making the change the "new normal". The Prosci ADKAR model emphasizes **Reinforcement** as its final stage – ensuring the change sticks through recognition, rewards, and integrating it into systems (prosci) (whatfix).

  Refinement includes this notion of reinforcing success: celebrate the completion of the change, highlight results achieved (which reinforces why the change was worth it), and formally acknowledge those who contributed.

Refinement is also a moment to **address any gaps** that surfaced. Recall we noted a potential weakness of CLEAR is that it doesn't explicitly mention "leadership" or "sponsorship" in the acronym. Here in Refinement (and indeed throughout the cycle), it's crucial to ensure leadership alignment is maintained. If new resources are needed for full rollout, leaders must step up and provide them. If the analysis uncovered stakeholder concerns, sponsors should help address them. In practice, many organizations incorporate a parallel workstream for *change management activities* (communication, stakeholder management, leadership engagement) alongside CLEAR's technical steps. That is a smart augmentation – CLEAR focuses on *what to do* to change processes or products, but the *people side* (skills, mindsets, buy-in) should be woven in. At Refinement stage, this means having leaders champion the successes, reiterate commitment, and ensure recognition and rewards align with the new behavior. (For example, if a sales process changed, the sales incentive plan may need updating – a refinement to ensure people don't revert to old habits.)

Let's revisit our **Starbucks** story to see refinement in action. After numerous changes – from store operations to product offerings – were piloted and analyzed, Starbucks moved to institutionalize the successful practices. One of Schultz's "Transformation Agenda" points was to *"ignite the emotional attachment with our customers"* (libraryhbsedu). How did they refine toward that goal? They introduced the **Pike Place Roast** (a new core coffee blend) based on testing customer preferences (libraryhbsedu). They launched a loyalty card and ramped up social media engagement once they saw positive trial results (libraryhbsedu). They also learned from their experiments in barista training – the national closure day was a hit in terms of media buzz and employee pride, so they refined their ongoing training programs to incorporate the elements that worked (e.g. institutionalizing "Espresso Excellence" standards across all stores). Moreover, by the end of the turnaround, Starbucks anchored these changes in its culture – bringing back the aroma of coffee in stores, enlisting partners in continuous improvement, and keeping that *connection* element at the forefront. In Kotter's terms, they *"anchored new approaches in the culture"*, which is the ultimate refinement and reinforcement of change.

Another brief example: **Earth Force's absorption model**. They refine their approach as they integrate into partner organizations. Some partners expanded Earth Force's 6-step model to 8 steps, or blended it with their own curricula (earthforce) – effectively local refinements to fit context. Earth Force embraced these adaptations (refinements) because they still served the mission. This flexibility in refinement is key – the end state might not look exactly like the initial plan, and that's okay if it meets the core objectives. The framework must allow tailoring so that the change truly *fits* the environment it's being applied to.

Refinement can sometimes loop back to **Clarity** for a final check: Has our vision been achieved, or does it need to be updated? In long transformations, the ultimate goal usually evolves. If so, re-clarify and continue the cycle. But assuming the change has reached a satisfactory new state, refinement segues into **sustaining** that change. This might involve setting up new feedback mechanisms to ensure the change holds (like periodic audits or pulse surveys), effectively creating a new steady state.

At the end of a CLEAR cycle, you should have: a well-defined change that's been tested, proven, and embedded; a set of stakeholders who are knowledgeable and committed (because they've been along for the journey); and measurable improvements aligned to your original goals. In short, you have not just a one-time change, but new **capability** in your organization – the capability to learn and adapt. That is the ultimate strength of the CLEAR framework: beyond solving the problem at hand, it leaves you better equipped for the next change, having fostered a culture of clarity, engagement, experimentation, and continuous learning.

Why CLEAR Works: The Science and Strategy Behind the Framework

The CLEAR framework's power comes from how it blends *human psychology*, *business pragmatism*, and *systems thinking*. Here we dissect why each component of CLEAR contributes to successful change, and how it stands on the shoulders of proven change management knowledge while addressing their limitations:

- **Clarity taps both logic and emotion:** Human beings need meaning. In times of change, a clear purpose satisfies the intellectual need to know "why," and the emotional need to feel part of something important. Neurological studies show people handle uncertainty better when they have a clear explanation and vision to focus on (reducing fear responses). Business-wise, clarity aligns efforts – it's far easier to coordinate actions when everyone knows the goal. This echoes lessons from leadership science: for example, **Kotter's model starts with urgency and vision**, because a compelling vision can inspire and guide large groups effectively (prosci). CLEAR's Clarity step ensures no change kicks off without that guiding star, preventing the common pitfall of "activity without direction."

- **Leverage empowers people, accelerates momentum and pinpoints the changes most likely to impact our goals:** Change is fundamentally a social process. By leveraging existing strengths and involving key players, CLEAR embeds change within the social fabric of the organization. This approach is validated by research on organizational networks – positive deviants (high-performers who find better ways to work) and informal influencers can pull their peers along. Kotter's emphasis on a broad guiding coalition and McKinsey's 7% rule (needing a critical mass of engaged employees) both reinforce that **engagement is the engine of change** (innovationone). Unlike approaches that rely purely on top-down mandates, CLEAR's Leverage step creates a groundswell from within, which is far more sustainable. It also aligns with **Appreciative Inquiry** principles: identifying *what works well* and doing more of it, rather than obsessing over weaknesses. This positivity can boost morale during change.

- **Experimentation introduces agility and reduces risk:** In a fast-changing world, a static one-and-done change plan is often outdated by the time it's executed. CLEAR's call for experimentation is a direct response to the need for **agility**. It mirrors practices from agile project management and Lean Startup methodology – build-test-learn cycles – which have revolutionized product development with faster innovation. Applying this to organizational change means you're not betting the farm on untested ideas. You're essentially doing *R&D for your transformation*, which dramatically increases the likelihood of success. It also keeps people engaged: an experimental approach invites contributions and creativity, turning employees into co-creators of the change rather than passive recipients. **Lean**

Change and public sector **Policy Labs** around the world have shown that even in large bureaucracies, iterative experimentation can break analysis-paralysis and produce better outcomes, as seen when prototyping entered the UK government's policy standards (openpolicy). CLEAR takes this ethos and makes it accessible to any change effort.

- **Analysis makes the process evidence-based and adaptive:** By insisting on analysis after action, CLEAR avoids one of the biggest traps: *flying blind*. Many change programs push forward without ever checking if the change is yielding the desired effect until it's too late. The Analysis step introduces a feedback loop, essentially building a **learning organization** as described by Peter Senge. The organization learns from each change effort, becoming smarter and more resilient. This data-driven approach speaks to the business-minded (logos) stakeholders who want to see ROI and justification. It also boosts credibility (ethos) – when you can show data or concrete observations backing your decisions, you earn trust. Analysis also helps tackle resistance: skeptics often object to change on grounds that it "won't work." By transparently analyzing and sharing results, you either alleviate those concerns with proof or acknowledge issues and refine, which demonstrates accountability. In short, Analysis in CLEAR ensures that *reality is shaping the change*, not just theory or assumptions.
- **Refinement ensures longevity and continuous improvement:** A change that isn't cemented will crumble—this is why Prosci's ADKAR ends with **Reinforcement** and Kotter ends with **Anchoring change in culture**. CLEAR's Refinement step encompasses those ideas, with an added notion of iteration. It's not just "make it stick," it's "make it better and then make it stick." This resonates with the Japanese concept of **Kaizen** (continuous improvement) and the PDCA cycle (theleanwa). It acknowledges that the first implementation of a change might not be perfect, and that's okay as long as you continuously refine. Importantly, this step is where CLEAR addresses the *people side* most directly: by refining training, incentives, and incorporating feedback, it closes the loop with those who must live with the change. It's also where leadership visibility matters immensely – celebrating wins, declaring the new status quo, and rewarding teams are all part of refinement. By proactively talking about these in the framework, we mitigate the criticism that CLEAR doesn't mention leadership: in practice, we weave leadership actions into **Clarity (setting vision)** and **Refinement (sponsoring and cementing the change)**, and indeed throughout as needed. The flexibility of CLEAR means you can plug in a *sponsor roadmap* or *ADKAR checklist* at appropriate points (for example, ensure Awareness and Desire are addressed in Clarity and Leverage; ensure Ability and Reinforcement are boosted in Refinement) – thus CLEAR can work *with* human-focused models seamlessly.

Finally, CLEAR's cyclical nature embodies **adaptive learning**. It treats transformation not as a one-time project but as a capability. Organizations that adopt CLEAR may find that they've developed a template for any change – big or small. After a few cycles, team members start naturally approaching challenges with clarity and experimentation. This cultivates an *innovation culture* and a readiness for change, which is arguably the biggest competitive advantage in a turbulent environment.

To sum up, CLEAR works because it is **holistic**: it speaks to the strategic level (Clarity), the social and systems level (Leverage), the tactical level (Experimentation and Analysis), and the cultural level (Refinement). It integrates the *ethos* of strong leadership and proven theory, the *logos* of data and process, and the *pathos* of vision and inclusive engagement. It's not reinventing the wheel – it's making the wheel turn faster and more smoothly for modern roads.

Addressing Common Concerns about CLEAR

Any framework benefits from healthy scrutiny. Two questions often arise about CLEAR: **(1) Where is the emphasis on leadership and sponsorship? (2) Could the cyclical approach lead to a never-ending process or lack of decisive action?** Let's tackle these candidly.

Leadership and Sponsorship: It's true, CLEAR as an acronym doesn't explicitly call out "Leadership" the way Kotter's model does (which mandates forming a powerful guiding coalition) (prosci). This is by design – CLEAR focuses on *what needs to happen* (vision, engagement, experiments, etc.), regardless of who initiates each part. However, this is not to downplay the role of leaders. In fact, CLEAR assumes that strong leadership is the *cornerstone* upon which Clarity is built and sustained. Someone has to articulate the vision and empower the team – typically this is top leadership for organization-wide change, or team leaders for local change. We encourage users of CLEAR to explicitly assign executive sponsors and change champions as part of the **Leverage** step (when assembling resources and allies). These sponsors should be accountable for driving the process and supporting teams through obstacles.

What CLEAR offers is flexibility: leadership can come from different levels as appropriate. For example, in a grassroots innovation, a middle manager might act as the change leader using CLEAR, later securing executive buy-in at the leverage stage when needed. In a company-wide strategic shift, the CEO might kick off Clarity and sponsor throughout. CLEAR works with either scenario. The key is to ensure **sponsorship is present even if it's not a named step** – consider it an underlying enabler for all steps. Many organizations pair frameworks; one might use CLEAR as the execution engine and add a governance layer from another model. For instance, Prosci's **PCT (Project Change Triangle)** or Kotter's coalition concept can overlay CLEAR to monitor that leadership, project management, and change management are all in sync. In short, CLEAR doesn't diminish leadership – it expects leaders to be active in providing clarity, removing barriers, and reinforcing change (especially at the first and last steps).

Iterative Cycles vs. Decision Paralysis: Another concern could be that continuous experimentation and refinement mean "we'll never finish" or that teams might use it as an excuse to tinker endlessly without making hard choices. In practice, CLEAR is results-oriented – the goal is to achieve the vision set in the Clarity step. Experiments are not aimless; they are designed to reach that target. The iterative nature simply means we remain open to learning and adapting on the way, not that we change the goals arbitrarily or linger unnecessarily. In fact, having the Clarity step up front prevents aimless iteration, because it provides a fixed point of reference.

Think of CLEAR like climbing a mountain via switchbacks: you know your summit (Clarity), you traverse (Experiment) and pause to check your bearings (Analysis), you

adjust your path if needed (Refinement), but you are always getting closer to the top. There is a built-in success criteria – once analysis shows you've met your goals (or as close as reasonably possible), the cycle ends for that initiative and becomes focused on sustaining the outcome. Also, the framework encourages *small, time-bound experiments*. This inherently prevents never-ending loops; each experiment should have a clear timeline and metrics. If an organization finds itself iterating without progress, that in itself will show up in the Analysis step (no improvement in metrics might indicate a flawed approach or even an ill-defined Clarity that needs revisiting). CLEAR's self-correcting nature means such issues are caught and addressed.

It's also worth noting that CLEAR can scale to the magnitude of the change. For a minor process tweak, you might run one or two quick Experiment→Analysis→Refinement cycles in a week and be done. For a major digital transformation, CLEAR might operate in waves over months or years. In big programs, you might have multiple CLEAR loops running in parallel for different workstreams, all feeding up to the overall transformation vision. This can be governed with a PMO (project management office) structure, again showing how CLEAR can integrate with formal project management and change management offices.

In summary, the potential weaknesses of CLEAR (lack of an explicit "L = Leadership" step, and the fear of iterative loops delaying closure) are manageable through conscious application. We *proactively recommend* building a strong sponsorship model into your CLEAR initiative from the start, and setting clear success criteria and timeframes as part of Clarity so that iteration is purposeful and finite. By doing so, you get the best of both worlds – strong leadership guidance *and* agile adaptation.

Real-World Impact: How CLEAR Principles Drive Success

The CLEAR framework might be new as a formal model, but its principles have proven themselves in many domains. Below are **real-world examples** where elements of CLEAR's approach led to transformational success. These cases span corporate, non-profit, and public sectors, demonstrating the versatility of the framework's ideas.

Starbucks' transformation (2008–2010) shows CLEAR in action: by returning to core values (Clarity) and empowering employees (Leverage), the coffee giant was able to experiment with bold changes and rejuvenate its brand.

- **Starbucks (Corporate Turnaround):** In 2008, Starbucks was in a tailspin – rapid over-expansion had diluted the customer experience and profits were plummeting. Howard Schultz's turnaround strategy embodied CLEAR principles. He began with *clarity of purpose*, declaring that Starbucks would *"return to its roots"* and uncompromising values (libraryhbsedu). The company identified what made it great (coffee artistry and community) and leveraged those strengths by *deeply engaging employees*: Starbucks closed every U.S. store for a day of barista training and later convened 10,000 store managers in New Orleans to rally

them as change leaders (libraryhbsedu). With buy-in secured, they launched experiments – e.g. testing lean operations in select stores to cut waste and improve speed. These trials were rigorously analyzed; when data showed that small operational tweaks could cut drink-making time and boost customer satisfaction, those changes were refined and rolled out chain-wide (bigthink) (6sigma). Within two years, Starbucks not only escaped decline but reignited growth, *anchoring new ways of working into its culture* without losing its soul. The transformation validated that a clear vision, engaged partners, iterative improvements, and constant learning could turn a company around (libraryhbsedu).

- **Earth Force (Community & Non-Profit Innovation):** Earth Force, an NGO focused on youth environmental action, needed to scale its impact nationally without massive growth of its own organization. Adopting a CLEAR-like strategy, Earth Force set a clear mission to integrate youth civic action into existing education systems (Clarity) and leveraged partnerships with schools and local groups (rather than building new offices) to spread its model (earthforce). They experimented with different integration approaches – some partners adopted Earth Force's standard 6-step youth action process, while others tweaked it to fit their curriculum (Experimentation & Refinement in practice). Earth Force closely tracked these collaborations, finding that about 60% of partner organizations fully embedded the principles after seeing positive results (Analysis) (earthforce). For instance, a water conservation district in New Mexico integrated Earth Force's model into their 5th grade program, which led to improved student engagement and an expanded reach to entire schools (earthforce). These insights allowed Earth Force to refine their partnership support and highlight success stories, further reinforcing the change in partner organizations. The outcome is a broad, sustained change in how youth environmental education is delivered across dozens of communities – achieved through clarity of mission, leveraging existing networks, and iterative adaptation. It's a powerful example of systems thinking: Earth Force changed the system by working *with* the system.
- **UK Policy Lab (Government Innovation):** Public sector change can be notoriously slow and risk-averse, but the UK Policy Lab proved that CLEAR-like methods can inject agility into government. Established in 2014 with a mandate to "radically improve policymaking through design and experimentation," the Policy Lab had top-down support but no guaranteed ongoing budget – essentially a one-year experiment by itself (themandarin). With that clarity of purpose ("show value or close") and backing from a senior official, the Lab leveraged a small multi-disciplinary team and the curiosity of civil servants across departments to start tackling policy challenges in new ways (they had to *influence without authority*, a form of leverage by building informal coalitions).

They ran **prototypes** on issues like housing and marine policy – bringing citizens and staff together to co-design solutions and test them cheaply (openpolicy). One early project on private renting produced novel ideas via prototyping that informed actual policy adjustments (openpolicy). The Lab meticulously documented results and methods (Analysis), which built credibility internally. As prototypes succeeded, the Lab refined its understanding, its approaches and toolkits (e.g. introducing game-based workshops for policy design) and scaled its influence to more departments. Over five years, despite initial skepticism, the Policy Lab became a fixture, inspiring similar labs globally. Its success stems from proving that even in government, a clear vision for citizen-centered policy, combined with leveraging creative talent, running controlled experiments, and learning fast, can solve problems that traditional approaches could not. This is essentially CLEAR transposed to bureaucracy: **vision + engagement + try/test + evidence + adapt** = breakthrough.

These stories are a compelling testament that the principles underlying CLEAR aren't theoretical – they *work* in practice. Starbucks revitalized a global business, Earth Force scaled impact through others, and the UK government innovated from within, all by following patterns of clarity, leveraging people, experimenting, analyzing, and refining. Each case also underscores an important point: CLEAR is *industry-agnostic*. Whether it's a coffee retailer, a non-profit, or a federal agency, the framework's human-centric and learning-centric approach is broadly applicable.

Conclusion: An Invitation to Transform with CLEAR

The CLEAR Change Framework offers a path to change that is both **practical in execution** and **profound in its impact**. It speaks to the head with structured steps and evidence, and to the heart with its emphasis on vision and empowerment. In an age where change is the only constant, organizations can no longer afford to treat transformation as a one-time project or a rigid plan to enforce. Instead, what's needed is a *change-capable culture* – one that can navigate uncertainty with confidence, much like a sailor who can adjust sails deftly in shifting winds while keeping the destination in sight. CLEAR is a framework to build that capability.

By integrating clarity of purpose, leverage of collective strengths, iterative experimentation, analytical rigor, and continuous refinement, CLEAR helps organizations **learn their way forward**. It creates conditions where employees at all levels feel involved and invested in the change, where leadership is actively guiding and clearing obstacles, and where the organization as a whole becomes more **adaptive, resilient, and innovative**. These are hallmarks of the most successful companies of our time – those that have turned market disruptions into opportunities to reinvent themselves.

Adopting CLEAR is more than using a new tool – it's embracing a mindset. It encourages humility (we don't assume we have all the answers), curiosity (every experiment is a chance to discover something new), and courage (willingness to act and to course-correct). And yet, it does so in a disciplined way that aligns with business realities – setting goals, measuring results, and focusing effort where it pays off. In essence, CLEAR marries the **entrepreneurial spirit** with **operational discipline**.

For leaders reading this whitepaper – executives, transformation directors, innovation team leads – consider this an invitation. **Imagine** your organization tackling its most daunting challenges using CLEAR: Employees at every level understand the mission and are pulling in the same direction; teams are launching pilots to address issues and coming to you with data-driven proposals for scaling what works; resistance gives way to excitement because people see tangible progress and feel heard in the process; and as each initiative concludes, the next one gets easier because you've built trust in the change process itself. This is not a fanciful scenario – it's the outcome that CLEAR is designed to deliver. It's what we've seen when these principles are applied diligently.

As the creator of CLEAR and a psychologist who has spent a career guiding change in behaviours and organizations, I, **Erik Bohjort** genuinely believe in the transformative power of this framework. It is rooted in how people and systems actually change – through understanding, involvement, trial, feedback, and adjustment. My team and I have built consulting practices around helping organizations implement CLEAR, tailoring it to their unique culture and challenges. We stand ready to walk alongside you in this

journey, not as directive experts, but as facilitators of your success – providing the validation, structure, and supportive push that gets the CLEAR cycle turning and keeps it on track.

In closing, if you seek a change approach that is **adaptive yet focused, comprehensive yet flexible, and rational yet deeply human**, CLEAR is your framework. Many talk about "change agility" as a critical asset in the 21st century; CLEAR gives you a concrete way to achieve it. We invite you to join the ranks of forward-thinking organizations that are not only surviving change but **thriving through it**, by making clarity, leverage, experimentation, analysis, and refinement the five pillars of their transformation story. The opportunity to change *better* is here – it's time to grab it with both hands and make your next change your greatest success.

Sources (for validation and further reading):

1. Prosci ADKAR Model – understanding individual change stages (whatfix).
2. Kotter's 8-Step Change Model – critique of linearity and need for agility (prosci).
3. Lean Change Management – using iterative "minimal viable changes" and feedback loops (pmi).
4. Starbucks Transformation – returning to core values and lean experimentation results (libraryhbsedu) (6sigma).
5. Earth Force Absorption Strategy – leveraging partnerships to scale impact (earthforce).
6. UK Policy Lab – prototyping policy and an experimental mandate in government (themandarin) (openpolicy)
7. McKinsey Research on Change – importance of broad engagement (7% rule) (innovationone).
8. PDCA Cycle – the power of iterative learning for continuous improvement (asq) (theleanway).
9. Starbucks Lean Results – reducing waste to improve customer experience (bigthink) (6sigma).
10. HBS Case on Starbucks – leadership clarity and values in transformation (libraryhbsedu).